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The Age of Merchants

With the collapse of Mauryan hegemony, the outer edges of the empire dissolved into smaller kingdoms. A rump empire continued under the Shunga dynasty. It was still a substantial realm and the northern and southern trade routes continued to flourish. The imperial court continued to maintain international diplomatic relations as evidenced by a stone pillar raised by Heliodorus, the Greek ambassador in Vidisha, a major pit-stop on the Dakshina Path. Nonetheless, the north-western parts of the subcontinent were steadily occupied by Indo-Greek kingdoms that evolved a culture based on a mix of Indian, Greek and Bactrian elements. However, climate fluctuations would again play an important role in the chain of events.

In the first century BC, a severe famine caused by excessive snow affected the area that we now call Mongolia.[1] This was an area inhabited by fierce tribes of nomads called the Xiongnu. It is uncertain exactly who these people were but they were probably forerunners of the Mongols. These tribes had been the bane of early Chinese civilization and had prompted the First Emperor to build the earliest version of the Great Wall. The great drought caused the Xiongnu to migrate into the lands of another Central Asian tribe called the Yueh-Chih. In turn, the Yueh-Chih displaced the Sakas (Scythians), the Bactrians and Parthians. One by one, these groups were forced into the subcontinent. Thus, Afghanistan and North West India saw a succession of invasions and migrations.